Imagine: The Killing of John Lennon

by Lee Brown



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TEASER

There was no anger. There was nothing. It was dead silence.

Dead. Cold. Quiet.

He looked at me, he walked past me, and then I heard the voice in my head. It said, "Do it, do it, do it, do it."

My whole life pointed in one direction. I can see that now. There wasn't any choice for me. Come on. Normal kids don't grow up to shoot a member of The Beatles. Bang, bang.

You're dead.

INTRODUCTION

Mark David Chapman single-handedly changed our musical landscape the day he shot John Lennon outside The Dakota apartment building in New York City on December 8, 1980. Chapman remained at the scene, reading JD Salinger's novel The Catcher in the Rye *until the police arrived and arrested him. Chapman repeatedly said that the novel was his statement, and that the murder was the will of God. Chapman was sentenced in 1981 and has been denied parole eight times. Through the actual accounts by Chapman himself, we gain great insight into the mind of this famous murderer.*

"Imagine: The Killing of John Lennon" adapted by Lee Brown, based on the screenplay by Andrew Piddington.

My mother was a dreamer, moody. Right out of *The Glass Menagerie*. I don't think I ever hugged my father. He never told me he loved me, and he never said he was sorry.

Sometimes I fantasized about getting a gun and blowing him away. My mother said she only married him to have me.

June 21, 1979.

I felt I was nothing, a nobody. I took refuge in public places. I loved the library. I was searching for some kind of guidance, a mission, and I found one. In a book. I hadn't read it since I was 16. Now it burned in my hand.

Chapter 27.

Here was something I could identify with: Holden Caulfield. I started reading *The Catcher in the Rye*, and I held it between my hands and put it against my face and I inhaled deeply an un-phony a way of life.

Then I found another way to feel. The music of John Lennon. What words, What feelings. What truth. Until the day I saw his cover of *TIME* magazine. Just as Holden Caulfield had bled through the ink of *Cathcher*, John Lennon now entered my mind. There he was, at the base of the Statue of Liberty with his expensive sunglasses, fur coat, designer clothes, and having his photograph taken.

After looking at that picture of him, I became enraged. Something inside me just ignited.
The great John Lennon who'd told us to imagine no possessions, it's easy if you try--

There he was with millions of dollars, and yachts, and clothes, and country estates,
laughing at people like me who believed all the lies and bought all the records.

It reeked of phoniness.

That was it--confirmation. As soon as I saw that picture, I knew I was going to kill him. It was like I had been handed something. A solution.

I'd sit up all night and play Beatles records, speeding them up, slowing them down, interjecting my own words. I was sending out telegrams to Satan.

"Give me the opportunity to kill John Lennon."

I was 25 years old. I'd made a decision.

"The phony must die," says *The Catcher in the Rye*.

Step back with me, won't you? A moment back in time. Come with me.

December 1, 1980 9:00 a.m.

The Charter Arms .38 is a fine, solid gun. Blue steel, snub nose. The same as a police revolver. It's handy, flexible, lightweight, reliable. And it's cheap to get a ticket to New York. One-way. You can take it to New York as you fill out a form and the firearm and ammunition are separate and in your luggage.

December 8, 1980 4:30 p.m.

There's a smell in New York. It's a scary smell, a cold smell, and I'm frightened of someone finding out my secret. Everybody knows Lennon lives up on 72nd Street. At The Dakota. I can't believe I'm really standing here, right outside where he lives.

Shooting a man is no easy thing. It takes a lot of inner strength. "The phony must die,"
says *The Catcher in the Rye*.

I've been here for a week. I see him all the time.

"Mr. Lennon? May I have your autograph? Here—can you put it on the jacket of this record? Oh, wow. Thanks."

"Oh, and can your friend take a picture of us? Here's my camera. Thanks, Mr. Lennon."

"What? You have a recording session? Oh. It's okay. I can wait. I have all the time in the world."

December 8, 1980. Now 10:50 p.m. Come with me. Let's go back and re-live this glorious moment.

It's so dark. I have his signed copy of "Double Fantasy" under my arm. The limo pulls up. I see John and Yoko step out.

Here we go.

"Mr. Lennon? JOHN!"

"The phony must die," says *The Catcher in the Rye*.

And I empty the .38 revolver. I shoot five times. Hit him four times. It was like I was in a movie. I thought he would just drop right in front of me and that was it. I thought he was just gonna fall down, like in the movies. Fall down dead. He was brought to the emergency room shortly before 11pm. He was dead on arrival.

A whole era ended. It was the last nail in the coffin of the groovy '60s. Lennon was DEAD.

Imagine that...

And that day, I became a savior, a prophet. Poor guy. To think that the great John Lennon makes his wildest dreams come true. Then he ends up murdered by somebody like me.

I'm changing now, becoming something new.

I'm going to be with you, Holden Caulfield. In the rye.

I'll just disappear into the ink of the book.

No, that won't happen. I murdered John Lennon. People will remember me.

"The phony had to die," says *The Catcher in the Rye*.

“Mr. Lennon? What a pleasure to meet you, sir.”

You may say I'm a dreamer
But I'm not the only one
I hope someday you'll join us
And the world will live as one...